



Dolores Jean Lavins Center for
Humanities in Medicine

The Tempest

Mayo Clinic Alix School of Medicine
Annual Creative Arts Publication
2023



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Foreword

From the somber and the serene to the wistful and the whimsical, we bring to you the 2023 edition of *The Tempest*. Now in its ninth year, *The Tempest* has grown not only in content, but also in its student contributors from across the Mayo Clinic College of Medicine and Sciences, and its readership across the Mayo Clinic and beyond.

Harking back to the origins of Mayo Clinic and paying homage to one of William Shakespeare's last plays, the title of *The Tempest* reminds us of the destructive power of storms, whether

on land or at sea, and the necessity of emotional and physical healing along with teamwork to recover and move forward past the storm together, as a class, as a family, as an institution, and as a community.

This year's whirlwind collection of poetry, prose, photography, and visual art takes us on a journey by patients' bedsides and into operating rooms, along winding outdoor trails to the front steps of heaven, past the Underworld and through wandering forests of wisdom, amid frigid snowstorms and

toward fiery sunsets, culminating with a quick glimpse of everyday living and a jiffy jaunt through the fantastical to close gently on a quiet moonrise after the storm.

We invite you to join us on this storm chase celebrating these snippets from the imaginations and lives of our students in the clinic, in the classroom, beyond, and within.



Sherry Zhou
Editor-in-Chief
Co-Editor, Written Arts



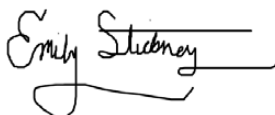
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Introduction

In 1959, Charles Percy Snow, an English scientist and novelist, delivered the annual Bede lecture at the University of Cambridge. The title of his address was *The Two Cultures and the Scientific Revolution*. The ‘Two Cultures’ Snow spoke of were ‘literary intellectuals’ on one side, and on the other, ‘natural scientists’. He noted that these two groups were divided by a gulf of mistrust and mutual misunderstanding. While a close reading of his text does not endorse fissuring knowledge in this way, a blistering and personal contretemps from the literary critic Frances Leavens unwittingly helped to reinforce this notion in the public imagination, in professional practice, and most notably, in our systems of education. It is a way of thinking that has proven to be powerful, broad in scope, and long in duration.

This way of siloing knowledge is no longer sustainable if existential problems are to be effectively addressed. Complex problems require complex solutions. A recent editorial from the National Academy of Medicine focusing on preparing for the next fifty years in health and medicine states “The challenges of the future require radical partnerships with a more diverse range of partners in health and beyond... The National

Academy of Medicine is committed not only to multidisciplinary collaboration but also to true convergence across fields because the problems of today and those of the future have consequences that radiate across sectors” (Dzau, VJ: Anticipating the Future of Health and Medicine-The National Academy of Medicine prepares for its Next 50 Years. JAMA, doi:10.100/jama.2023.4081). Science and technology will create the tools. Who has access to these, and how they are used to forge a future practice of social justice that ensures health care equity and the promise of human sustainability will require the imagination and creativity that are part and parcel of the practice of the Health Humanities.

Thus, it is an honor and privilege to help introduce this Ninth Edition of *The Tempest*, written and produced by our junior colleagues in the Mayo Clinic College of Medicine and Science. As with each preceding edition, it represents a remarkable collection of artistic and literary contributions that reflect the value and creativity of gifted individuals capable of working within and across disciplines. Each submission in its own way represents reflective thought, imagination, and a

sense of presence to self and to the ‘other’. Each offers a moment of respite from the demands of an attention economy with multiple priorities demanding our focus. Now, more than ever, the imagination represented in these objects helps us to see through the clouds the promise of hope and a commitment to ourselves and each other for a brighter future.

On his 70th birthday, Dr. William J. Mayo made the following observation: ‘I look through a half-opened door into the future, full of interest, intriguing beyond my power to describe, but with a full understanding that it is for each generation to solve its own problems and that no man has the wisdom to guide or control the next generation’ (Clapesattle H: The Doctors Mayo, London, Oxford University Press, 1941: 701-702). This group of students represents the next generation of physicians, those that will help create and curate the next half-century in healthcare. This issue of *The Tempest*, and all that preceded it, reminds us that it takes a village, and the village is in good stead.

Daniel K. Hall-Flavin, MD, MSc
Medical Director, The Dolores Jean Lavins Center for the Humanities in Medicine
Mayo Clinic, Rochester MN

In their 2022 letter to the editor in *Academic Medicine*, Yeonsoo Sara Lee and Rebecca Bihun state, “We have learned to see art and medicine not as competing interests, but as synergistic passions informing each other.” Describing themselves as “doctor-artists,” Lee and Bihun assert that their identity as both doctors and artists has opened up new transdisciplinary opportunities, enabled them to “[explore] emerging scientific knowledge in greater depth,” and reinforced for them “the many benefits of mindful engagement with the arts” (Lee Y.S., Bihun B.: “The Practice of My Art”: Finding Synergy in Creative and Clinical Pursuits, *Academic Medicine*, October 25, 2022).

This Ninth Edition of *The Tempest* showcases the work of Mayo Clinic College of Medicine and Science learners like Lee and Bihun, who are leading the way as doctor-artists. The collection reveals the myriad ways in which these talented individuals are integrating arts and humanities into their lives and their medical training. Contributors draw upon the arts to engage with scientific data, to reflect, to grapple with challenging circumstances, and to be more present in their own lives, in

the lives of others, and in the world around them. Each piece and perspective in the collection is unique, yet some themes emerge: temporality, artistic and intellectual curiosity, the comfort of the mundane, and the importance of relationships with family, peers, and patients. Several pieces focus on identity, either on the process of establishing a new identity as a future physician or on retaining one’s former self in the context of medical training. Multiple works reflect a loss of control: Jean Marrero-Polanco refers to “those of us who have felt lack of control over our lives,” Emily Stickney employs the word “consume,” and Mazed Aro-Lambo chooses “engulf.” In these works, we confront the heart-wrenching question: What does it mean to be consumed, engulfed?

Indeed, perhaps most prevalent in the collection is a tug between light and dark, foreboding and hope. In Taylor Viggiano’s cover photograph “Looming,” dark clouds hover ominously, with sunlight peeking through. Again and again in this volume, both in artistic medium and in content, we face the question: what will prevail?

To the question, there also is an answer: light, hope. Nathan Chow takes us from a “darkened nervous night” to a pledge to “build our own sunrise.” Santiago Restrepo Castillo looks to the promise of a better future: “I believe that day will come, and I will work hard to make it happen.” And in the words of Dileep Monie, “In the darkest of days, there’s a glimmer of light.”

I am grateful to these doctor-artists for sharing parts of their journey with me, and I am deeply honored to help introduce their work to you. Dr. Dan Hall-Flavin notes in his introduction that “complex problems require complex solutions.” The doctor-artists featured here demonstrate the skill and the courage to engage with the complex problems that they encounter in their lives and to respond with reflexivity, intellect, artistry, and hope.

Kathleen Van Buren, Ph.D.
Director, Humanities in Medicine
Mayo Clinic

The Cave

BY HANNAH HABERECHT

Linocut print on paper



Hospital Medicine

BY YONG-HUN KIM

How it must feel to lie there,
Whisked through endless turns.
Sinking deeper into the dull white sheets,
You hear conversation—but don't listen.
It doesn't concern you anyway.
Instead, lying supine
You find the deafening, white lights
That expose all.
How does one feel both overstimulated
Yet desensitized?
By the time you arrive at the destination,
There is no need for anesthesia.
Your senses are already dull.
You no longer react to the foreign touch of gloves.
You no longer laugh at the nurse's jokes.
Your mind wanders
Until that too starts to lose feeling
And you are relieved of your body.

Ode to the Pancreas

BY MARISA SALAZAR

"Eat when you can
Sleep when you can
But most of all, just
Don't mess with the pancreas"
Declare the surgeons to their acolytes
Before e'er a pancreas enters their sights

Before my credibility is shot
Among those to whom this phase has been taught
It should here be noted
That in the quote above quoted
I have taken liberty to change
Some--*ahem*--strong language

So, what is it about the pancreas
That causes all this fervor and fuss?
Salivary glands are exocrine too
But aren't subjected to such a to do.
The hormones from many an endocrine gland
Have pill replacements if surgery is planned.

It's true that the little adrenals
Are treated gently as a general rule.
But even the liver, which shares both designations,
Is commonly "messed with" for a donation.
So why the apprehension for this stubborn
Organ, which truthfully looks like blubber?

Head in the duodenum and tail at the spleen
So covered by stomach, it can barely be seen.
Making lipase and trypsin to break down food
And also the hormones that put one in a mood
To eat or stop eating. It's a powerful master
And if it's upset, there's impending disaster.

It can wreak havoc as if to spite us--
The feared and formidable pancreatitis.
Epigastric pain radiates back,
Nausea and vomiting commence their attack.
The less lucky persons have shortness of breath,
Sepsis, necrosis, organ failure, even death.
What started this madness, is the question?
This destructive turn towards autodigestion?

It's tough to figure out what went wrong;
The list of what sets it off is quite long:
Gallstones, alcohol, scorpions, hypercalcemia,
Meds, CMV, trauma, hypertriglyceridemia,
And on and on the list goes.
Then there's the causes we don't even know.

So, what is it about the pancreas
That causes all this fervor and fuss?
An organ controlling blood sugar levels,
Making digestive enzymes, but sometimes a rebel
Instigating diseases which are quite serious.
The answer may forever remain mysterious.

Surgical Scissors

BY EMILY STICKNEY

Digital artwork

surgery consumed me.
the word "consume" makes it sound
like i didn't fight back
i wonder if there is a moment
when someone is being consumed by lions
or a great depth of icy, murky water
when they stop kicking and screaming
suddenly understanding,
accepting,
deep in the thick of it,
that their fate is inevitable.



He just wanted a Nintendo Switch

BY SANTIAGO RESTREPO CASTILLO

He wanted a Nintendo Switch and his cousin had MELAS, an incurable genetic disorder. She had MELAS, *had* because she passed away. She was 7 and he was 10. He just wanted a Nintendo Switch. His cousin died and he started a business. He donated the money to the United Mitochondrial Disease Foundation. But his cousin still died, and she was still 7, and he was still 10, and he still just wanted a Nintendo Switch. He just wanted a Nintendo Switch.

In her speech, a mom talks about her daughter, who suffers from MELAS. As a panelist, in front of researchers and families alike, her voice breaks and she just wants to cry. She has to pause and collect herself, apologize and try to make it through the rest of her speech without breaking down again.

We're trying to help. I'm trying to help. But I'm ashamed. I've been looking for prestige, but these are people, these are real people, this is *real* suffering, this is *real* pain. This is a kid that wanted a Nintendo Switch and his cousin died of MELAS. This is a mom that cries because her daughter has an incurable disease that won't ever let her live a life like the one I'm getting a five thousand dollar research award and putting it on my CV. I'm going to lab and trying to clone some plasmids after a coffee break. I'm getting on a plane and thinking about a LinkedIn post. And I'm ashamed. I'm ashamed because this isn't about me. This is about them. This is about them and their suffering. This is about their *lives*, *their* dead, *their* dreams, *their* frustrations, *their* souls, *their* humanity.

I want to help. I want that the little boy that wants a Nintendo Switch can just buy one and play with his cousin, not having to worry about how he can help stop an incurable disease. I want the mom to see her daughter growing up strong and healthy and beautiful and free of constant pain. I want that connections like ours don't ever have to be formed again. I dream of a day when there isn't such a thing as a mitochondrial disease foundation, for that day there won't be any mitochondrial diseases. Little boys will play Nintendo Switch with their cousins, and moms won't have to cry in front of groups of concerned yet powerless strangers. I believe that day will come, and I will work hard to make it happen.

Samantha

BY YULIYA PETUKHOVA

Graphite on paper



Untitled

BY JENNIFER FEIGIN



Untitled

BY JENNIFER FEIGIN



Far Cry

BY MAIA YOUNG

Just this morning
Our mannequin
Had resumed spontaneous
Breathing, every time
Every
Time
And, pleased with our
Performance, the instructor
Encouraged us to move
Towards, not flee from
That euphemism
Concealed in ceil:
Code blue

So when that voice from
Up above calmly
Recited her script
Announcing asystole
In room 742
I was moved
To move
And the acuity of the
Whole thing,
This time, the real thing
Welcomed my willingness

I un-braked then
Re-braked the bed
Just like this morning
I stood at the ready,
A reserve officer
Next in line for duty
Just like this morning
And my confident
Offer to secure
The ventilatory seal
Was accepted
Just like this morning
When my fingers found
His jaw to thrust
Into the bag valve mask,
My desperately firm grip
Masked my feelings
As I waited
And waited
And kept waiting
For his chest to rise
For his eyes to flutter

Just this morning our mannequin had resumed spontaneous breathing, dammit!

Animation was
Officially suspended –
Forever for one of us –
At 1302 EST
After which came
No applause, no congratulations
(Death has no admirers)
And every sacred moment
I had just lived
Moving air, moving me
To move him, to save him
Breathed new meaning
New gratitude
Old joy
Lost innocence
In simulation

Harbor

BY ELIZABETH FARKOUH



Spinal Cord Conclave

BY EMILY STICKNEY

Acrylic on canvas



Treasure

BY ELIZABETH FARKOUH



The Gates of Heaven

BY TAYLOR WITTER

When he entered the gates of heaven,
The sun sparkled on the golden bars,
The gates slid open,
Like an automatic door made just for him.
The years of cancer,
The memories of war,
Trickled off of him,
They did not belong here.

His father and mother awaited him,
Hands interlocked and warm smiles,
His father's body was intact and lively,
Despite the explosion when he was only 2 years old,
And his mother wore a beautiful youth,
Just as she always had.
He entered into their arms,
Pain did not have a place here.

When you arrived at the gates of heaven,
The sun did not glisten,
off the closed gold bars,
There was no sign of a welcome,
or hint of preparation for your presence.
You knocked on the gates and called for someone,
Your anguish had escaped,
But relief had not found its way to you.

People arrived on the other side,
Your grandmother in her early 20s,
Your hibachi-san from your childhood in Japan,
They greeted you with happy
But perplexed looks.
The gates creaked open,
The grating metal whispering,
“Oh,
We were not expecting you.”

Golden Hour

BY NEIL SINHA



Fall-ing Rapids

BY REWAN ABDELWAHAB



Sisyphus's Shroud

BY NATHAN CHOW

I've said it--there.
Let's sit instead and stare.
See Sisyphus chase the endless horizon,
racing to first place to nowhere,
sinking, as he fades in shades
of lush and red and
painting the palms both burnt and black.
And in that darkened nervous night,
a way's away from any prize,
Just hold the hands that hold you tight.
We'll build our own sunrise.

Quarry Hill, Rochester, MN

BY ANJALI PANICKER



Cliffside

BY REWAN ABDELWAHAB



Gift of Gab

BY DERRICK LEWIS

If you weren't paying attention, you could almost miss it – something between a lisp and slur. Ganny had always had the gift of gab. She spoke a mile a minute on most days; on a long-distance phone call you could mistake her for an auctioneer. But now, every so often, her lips betrayed her.

My father wondered if Ganny had had a stroke. No one could remember her being weak on one side or the other. Her smile was just the same – no facial droop. She lived well. She ate well, did her daily walks at Curves, and still giggled girlishly whenever she sipped on weak strawberry daiquiris. But here we were, with a slur that wouldn't abate.

"Slow down momma" – my father would say to her. "You're just talking too fast." It seemed reasonable. Maybe she did talk too fast. Maybe that was wishful thinking. We couldn't really understand her anymore. Ganny started to avoid talking on the phone.

By now, Ganny had had all kinds of scans. She hadn't had a stroke as best the doctors could tell. My father would ask me, "What do you think?" I was only in my first-year of medical school, but I was already a doctor in my family's eyes. "I don't know."

Nearly two years after her words first garbled, we did know. She had finally found a doctor who could tell her what it was. It was ALS.

My father told me over the phone. Even half the country away, I could tell he was overcome with tears. I felt a mixture of sadness...and relief. At least we knew what we were dealing with. At least we knew what to expect. I had learned about ALS by then in medical school. Maybe I could help my family understand.

It was a cruel irony that Ganny lost her speech first. She still thought just as fast, walked just fast, and (to my chagrin) drove just as fast. At first, she could get by texting on a tablet. For her, it was maddeningly slow, but at least she could still communicate. Then swallowing became more difficult; eating was a chore. She still loved cooking for her grandsons, but eating a meal now took her hours; her food would need to be reheated multiple times. She began to lose weight. And she began to lose the independence that she had worked so hard to attain.

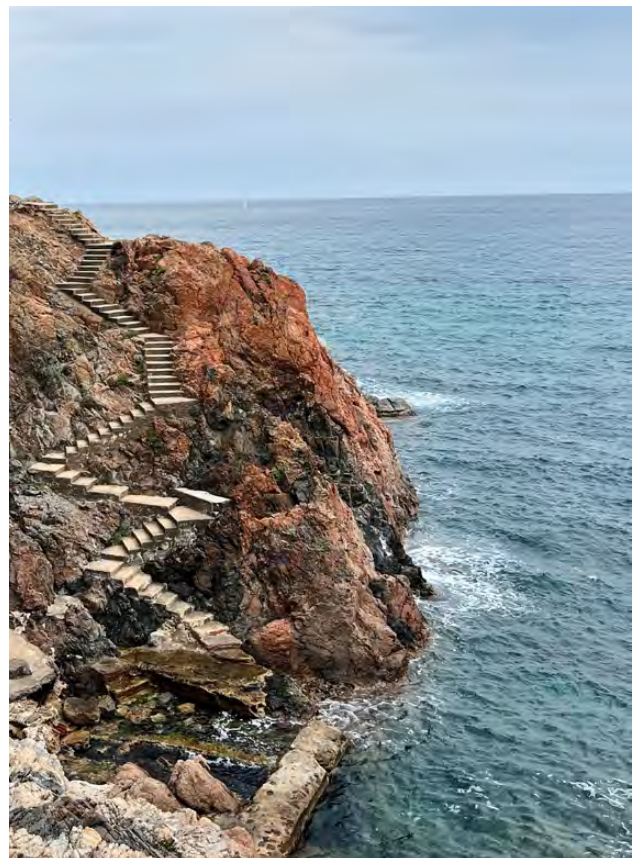
Ganny had survived a childhood in the Jim Crow South, moving to Chicago, two husbands, and 30 years as a nurse.

She had so many stories to tell. So many stories that I wish I could've listened to in-between studying and work. Now she couldn't tell them. Now I couldn't listen to them. But we were lucky that she could still share her love. She did it with her eyes, with the powerful rocking of her limbs, and a high-pitched squeal every time I held her.

I was not there in the end. I was not there when she could no longer move her head. I was not there when her moan in prayer and hope became a plea to escape the body that now betrayed her. I don't know if I should've been there. At the time, I thought it was okay to love from afar, busy with classes and exams, patients and their families. I'm not so sure anymore.

Sea to Sky

BY LAUREN BRESLIN



Stargazer

BY YULIYA PETUKHOVA

Gouache and colored pencil on paper



Grandmother

BY VYANKA REDENBAUGH

If someone asked who I most admire,
Without hesitation, "my grandad."
Courageous, strong, a bright red fire,
All these traits I wished for but never had.

My granny, not one to be left behind,
Sweet and gentle; nicest person to live.
I would like to think that I already am kind,
So there wasn't a lot for her to teach or to give.

I'd also like to think that love somehow lasts,
The one thing with meaning, even death it defies.
But even love dies, as people's death forecasts.
"Always" is a myth, "forever" is just lies.

Foolish girl, did you even stop to think?
The only reason for any kindness you bring,
Is because she taught you how, in a nod and a wink,
Without you ever realizing it. Now let that sting.

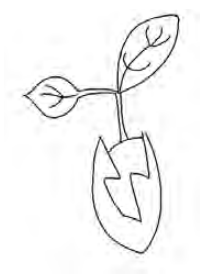
Those who have faith in heaven, much I envy.
To reassure oneself without second thought,
"you'll reunite with them one day, you see".
Alas, the first law of thermodynamics is all I've got.

From stars to plants to people it'll go.
But her atoms will forever leave an imprint.
If an evil man ever changes, I'll know,
Part of him has now gained her tint.

Changes

BY NEHA DEO

He said I miss you,
And I said I miss me too.



Reflection

BY NEHA DEO

I spent so long thinking about who I wanted to be,
I didn't think about who I am.



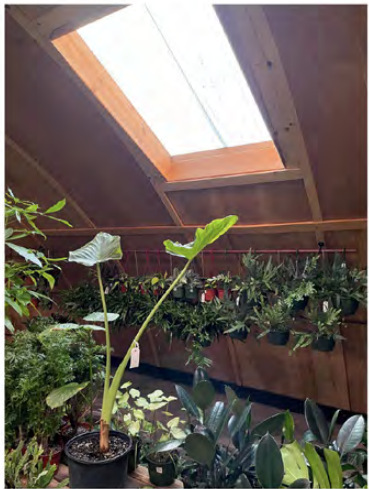
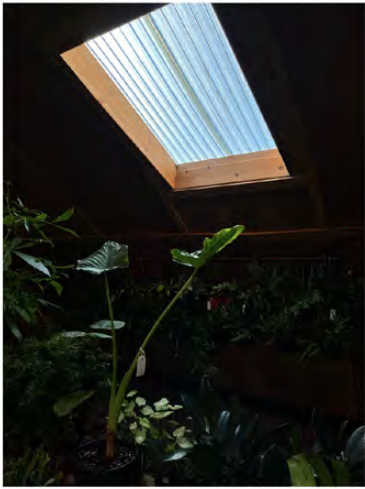
Vitality

BY REWAN ABDELWAHAB



Growth

BY ISRA ABDULWADOOD



Disability is not Inability: Reaching Out for Understanding

BY DILINA WEERAPPERUMA

As a 3rd year physical therapy student, I have learned a lot about the variety of disabilities we will work with as practitioners. However, the classroom only took me so far. I know now that academic knowledge does not equate to inclusivity, and I learned this the hard way. Outside of school, I signed up to become a coach for a local bowling team of athletes with disabilities: My intention was to put my academic knowledge to the test to try and make a difference in these athletes' performance with my perspective as a student physical therapist. Little did I know, I was up for a much greater challenge than I anticipated.

When I arrived at the first bowling practice, I was assigned a group of athletes to work with. As I greeted each of my new team members, I noticed that they varied in age, ethnicity, and more. Before that day, I had not considered how uniquely different people with disabilities may be, even if their designated disability puts them "in a box." As practice began, I was immediately faced with a challenge: One of my team members was wheelchair-bound. As I looked around frantically for a solution, another coach came up to me and gave me a device called a bowling ramp. The contraption allowed my wheelchair-bound team member to place their bowling ball on a ramp with steel rails that helped guide the ball down onto the lane. I was both embarrassed and intrigued. How could I have not been prepared for such a situation? But also, what a nifty tool!

As practice continued, another challenge faced me: One of my team members kept rolling their bowling balls into the gutter, and I could see their increasing frustration. I wanted to help them, but knew their disorder affected their coordination. How could I make the task easier for the player? Suddenly, a thought came to me. Perhaps they were having trouble with their hand-eye coordination as the bowling pins were 60 feet away. But the lane arrows were just 12 feet away! Upon this realization, I advised them to aim not for the middle of the pins, but rather, the middle arrow. With a little encouragement, the player stepped up to the line, bowled the ball through the middle arrow, and hit a strike! This player turned around with a big ear-to-ear grin. I cheered, and we exchanged a high five. I am sure the player was elated, but I felt just as satisfied. "I was able to make a difference," I thought to myself, "I can help someone with a disability *gain* an ability!"

Throughout the season, I learned more and more about working with individuals with disabilities. It was no longer just about the bowling. I had made friends with my team members, and we gained a mutual understanding of each other. I understood each of their abilities and how to bolster their weaknesses, and they understood my intention to help them succeed. Nothing brought me more joy than seeing my players' joy. I realized that even though I was not providing patient care through clinical experience, I gained something more fundamental and important: the ability to include. Without the coaches' guidance, these athletes with disabilities would not have been able to participate in their sport. Not for a lack of ability but rather, a lack of opportunity. Society is not built to support these individuals, so it takes a special, intentional effort to make the so-called "impossible" possible. But here these bowling athletes were, proving that they *can* do it, and that they *do* belong.

Switching perspectives to physical therapy, I realized that learning about and including individuals with disabilities are different concepts. I gained much from my coaching experience, and for physical therapy students out there, I recommend reaching out for understanding. Find a team, club, or event for people with disabilities. Meet these people, work with these people, and try to understand these people. If your experience is anything like mine, you will find that people with disabilities are not so different from us. With a little helping hand, you can turn society's preconceived notion of disability in an individual into a flourishing ability. As a profession, we can educate our students by bringing in people with disabilities to the classroom. We almost always hear their stories through the lens of a medical professional; removing the filter of the medical professional's perspective will bring us closer to a genuine understanding of the experiences of people with disabilities. Let them tell their stories, and let students ask questions from them. The first step to inclusion is understanding, and this is achieved when students interact with the people and not just their disability. Over time, these efforts to reach out for understanding will create better-equipped clinicians who understand the truth that disability does not mean inability, and rather, these individuals have the ability to succeed!

The Afterbirth

BY JESSICA WENG

The “placenta,” is more of a stage name.
It is the original embrace [of mother and child]
they fasten to each other
with a chain, or a trunk
that ushers
with reaching branches
which flower into vermillion lobes.
They grow into a starburst pattern of vessels
Alien to us, but
for the baby, it is the universe itself
encased in pearl sheen curtains.
It is militant
A shield, concealed and carried, in serried ranks
Filtering waste and passing nutrients
Usually expelled from the body without thanks
Or is it nurturing?
Passing on beautifully structured four-ringed notes
A promise of care and comfort to the growing baby, it dotes
Or is it a peer?

A business partner, exchanging transactions carefully
In this 40-week economy
With the danger of closing market early
Or the threat of creating a blockade,
disallowing trade with the larger world
It plays many parts and roles
But there are still many mysteries about its goals
In the afterbirth, it secedes
Gaining independence, it proceeds
Into gloved hands
As we work to discover and understand
Its secrets, mysteries, and plans

Sunset over Horseshoe Bend

BY NEIL SINHA



Looking Ahead

BY LAUREN BRESLIN



What the tadpole said to the medical student

BY MAZEED ARO-LAMBO

Inspired by Clint Smith

You and I have a lot in common
New to our worlds
Learning how to swim in an environment
That seems designed to engulf us

Struggles deep, future uncertain
Feeling fragile through it all
They tell us to just keep swimming
That we will develop and mature with time

So I guess

We must trust the journey
As we navigate these unforgiving currents
Metamorphosis to come
With new abilities we didn't know we had

We must make peace with the frustration
Born out of recognizing that
We've come so far
But have so much further to go

iLOOMination

BY ANJALI PANICKER



The seasons in Minnesota have taught me to be adaptable. During the summer, I enjoy hiking, biking, kayaking, being outdoors, and getting some vitamin Sun. Winters, on the other hand, allow me to pick up new hobbies and hone my skills. For me, 2021 was the year of embroidery. In 2023, I hope I'll learn to crochet and macramé. 2022 was a year of loom knitting, and it has been iLOOMinating...

Here are a few lessons I took away from this hobby:

1. Consistency

To build a mountain you must start with a molehill. I found that breaking down a project into doable tasks and making regular, albeit gradual progress made it less overwhelming and more fun.

2. Hygge

Enjoy the quiet pleasures of life. I made knitting my end-of-the-day ritual. It taught me to slow down and take breaks, unlike Billy Joel's ambitious, crazy child.

3. Ctrl + Z : undo & then redo

Some mistakes you can roll with and incorporate into your plan. For others, you must process the frustration, calm down, rewind, and redo. Occasionally, I had to take a few steps back to make a few leaps forward... knitting, frogging, and re-knitting!

4. Level up

Challenge yourself to level up. First, I began with yarn of one color, then two, then three, then different patterns. I started with swatches, then potholders, followed by scarves, bags, and beanies. It became exciting to try something new with each project.

5. Gifting

Experience the joy of personalized handmade gift-giving. The joy, warmth, and love it spreads are worth the time and effort. Knitting made holiday gifting fun and special.

6. Decision-making

Choose the right fibers to get the best fabric. The fibers you choose have a great impact on the finish of the final product. Selecting yarn, I found, was much like selecting your inner circle - the people you surround yourself with to enrich your life.

7. Solitude & Companionship

Some projects are fun solo, but sometimes it's better to tag team it. Once I found someone to share this hobby with, each project became so much more enjoyable.

8. Planning

Planning is great, but don't overthink it. Every once in a while, I ended up with something better than I had started out seeking and envisioning. I learned to be open to surprises.

9. Patience

Yarns, like relations, join, tangle, unravel, and break. It takes time, willingness, and patience to create something unique. See also: the concept of musubi (non-food) from Kimi no Na wa / 君の名は or Your Name.

10. Multi-tasking

Sticking with a single project can get dull. To combat that, I dabbled around with various projects simultaneously. The holiday season made me prioritize the projects that were gifts and ensured I brought every project to the finish line.

11. Regenerative knitting

Some projects leave you with bits of yarn. I recycled these seemingly useless tiny skeins of yarn into other projects or came up with new ideas simply to put them to use. The satisfaction of creating from waste cannot be put into words.

12. Knitting=Ph.D.

At some point along the way, you question the project, the idea, the plan, and the decision. It is only toward the end that you start making sense of it all.

Oh, The Things You'll Discover When You Fail

BY DILEEP MONIE

In a lab, in a hall, in a place you may know,
A medical scientist was working, with a frown from head to toe.
They'd been trying for months, and had nothing to show,
And the thought of their blunders made them feel quite low.

They studied the brain, its cells, and its might,
And the tumors that grew, that cancerous blight.
They'd been seeking a way to make it take flight,
But so far, their experiments were a frustrating fight.

Then they had an idea, something out of the norm,
To harness the power of the immune system's storm.
They tried something new, and it broke standard form,
But then something happened, a new viral swarm.

They realized they'd found it, the answer they sought,
The path to beat cancer, a new paradigm wrought.
Training T cells and B cells to fight as they ought,
Such a revelation could change the game, change the whole plot.

They raced down the hall, to tell their colleagues the news,
And they were amazed, they were wowed, they were quite amused.
They realized that failure was just a part of the ruse,
And that this innovation was a treasure, a real boon to use.

For neuro-oncology had now met with immunology,
A match made in heaven, true epistemology.
And the future was bright, full of hope and virology,
A way to kill glioma, a bold ideology.

So let this be a lesson, to keep victory in sight,
For in the darkest of days, there's a glimmer of light.
And with hard work and perseverance, everything will be alright,
And you too can make a discovery, to change the world's plight!

Untitled

BY ANANYA PAPPU



Wasted Hands

BY NING MCKENZIE

“How long?” she asks, a wasting form shivering
Wrapped in a sheet, her long fingers quivering
Soft wrinkles hinting at places she’s been
My eyes tearful, averted; I defer once again
I speak and the glass wall between us shatters
“We’re here for you” misses what actually matters

As her stay is extended, we watch every sunrise
I dread when she’s discharged, I fear our goodbyes
I rush every morning to see her slim silhouette
Her warm smile that greets me, I cannot forget
She holds out her hands, inviting but thin
Her humor and grace I still carry within

I lay awake pondering her future and fate
Will she still be here in a month at this rate?
Her face loses glow while her cheekbones gain angles
Neat fingernails twirling an arm full of bangles
Impatience grows stronger yet her hope remains
I hold onto my faith in modern medicine’s reins

My first cancer patient, the one I had dreaded
To her disease and its lessons, I am indebted
I dream of the day that our paths re-cross
That familiar smile no longer burdened by thoughts
And grandchild in arm, her hands now strong
I hope she lives that way, and lives that way long

Through the Trees

BY EMILY STICKNEY

Acrylic on canvas



2022: The Past, Stoicism, and Moving Forward

BY JEAN MARRERO-POLANCO

From breakups to adopting an ancient philosophy, and to finding myself, 2022 left a mark on my journals. Yes, journals plural. Even with therapy, a small, aesthetically pleasing notebook was key for conversing with my soul. The past can haunt us from time to time, but my introduction to stoicism changed my perception of past events. It was Seneca who said, “We suffer more often in imagination than in reality.” Nothing could better summarize what I was going through.

For those of us who have felt lack of control over our lives, either due to socioeconomics, family expectations, struggles in education, or trauma, we feel we’ll have control once we reach independence and adulthood. If we don’t, we may revert to the desperate child who wanted acceptance from our mom, dad, classmates, church, society, etc. Our defense mechanism automatically defaults to catering to societal expectations. We think life is easier when everyone is pleased, but this practice is self-destructive and unsustainable. No one wants to feel alone, and we might be tempted to tell the story that gets us a foot in the door and fake-it-until-we-make-it©. But what does “making it” look like? Is it the number of followers, your social status, or power? Is it spinning a narrative to the detriment of others to benefit yourself? I am reminded of the biblical verse (Mark 8:36-37): “For what shall it profit a man, if he shall gain the whole world, and lose his own soul? Or what shall a man give in exchange for his soul?” Despite the religious significance of this verse, I find it secularly relevant because of the many people sacrificing their true selves to obtain the superficial appearance of happiness, power, and societal reverence. As the NFT crowd shouts: “it’s not about its real value, it’s about its perceived value.” Marcus Aurelius elaborates on this human inclination:

“Consider the lives led once by others, long ago, the lives to be led by others after you, the lives led even now, in foreign lands. How many people don’t even know your name. How many will soon have forgotten it. How many offer you praise now—and tomorrow, perhaps, contempt. That to be remembered is worthless. Like fame. Like everything.”

His solution:

“Give yourself a gift: the present moment. People out for posthumous fame forget that the Generations To Come will be the same annoying people they know now. And just as mortal. What does it matter to you if they say x about you, or think y?”

His conclusion:

*“It never ceases to amaze me: **we all love ourselves more than other people but care more about their opinions than our own.**”*

Our egos drive most of this urge. We tell ourselves: “If I don’t react now, I’m not respecting myself. If I don’t show them a piece of my mind, then it’ll prove them right!” The desperate child inside wants to beat the game of social power, wants respect and control, but maybe the best way to win such a game is to not play at all (🎵Losers Club – Durry🎵 [Minnesotan band]). We don’t have to react impulsively. We don’t have to “get back at them.” *“Regardless of what they may say, we know what we are about, and the best retribution is to not become like your enemy”* – Marcus Aurelius.

(This YouTube video dives more into this subject: *My Summary of The Meditations of Marcus Aurelius* | (22 Stoic Principles) by Vox Stoica)

I will be sharing my 2022 journey based on my 2022 journal entries, which include: 1) a title, 2) 🎵 a song that I connected with🎵, and 3) my thoughts.

If anyone resonates with these, I’d love to hear from you. The reality is that there is nothing new under the Sun, and we are all in this together.

Winter’s Loss

(🎵My Castle Town – Deltarune🎵)
Gossips, miscommunication, and affected egos: the perfect recipe for disaster.

Whenever we start a program or a job, we depend on the knowledge of those who went before us. We rely on their insights about the position in question, but also on the social atmosphere. We trust that these friendly faces want to help us out, to give us a head start before we encounter any preventable troubles or specific people. The bond we develop with these guides can develop into a friendship. Clearly, these guides have had more time to hone their opinions of the program and of others. Over time, we develop our own opinions of the program and the people we were warned about, which can conflict with what our guides initially told us. It can turn out we can have vastly different relationships with these specific people compared to our guides. Nonetheless, we continue relying on them to introduce us to new people and join their social circles.

Interestingly, we find that we have opinions about people we’ve never met. Even worse, we feel like we must start picking sides or risk losing a friendship. We say: “What does it matter? At least I have my group.” What matters is when the unexpected hits: a fight. Fight between friends can happen and how we handle them is a determining factor in how things will move forward. Willingness to understand, communicate, and compromise becomes crucial under these circumstances. But that doesn’t always happen...

After a friendship breaks, our social circles break apart, people we once thought of as our friends begin choosing sides, and people who we don't know develop unfounded opinions of us. We feel alone, we don't know who to talk to or trust anymore. Gossip runs rampant over our lives like wildfire. It becomes too late to acknowledge what we saw before, but never acknowledged: if this is how they treat others, don't be shocked when we end up treated the same way.

Spring's Healing

(🎵)Chin Music for the Unsuspecting Hero
– Foster the People(🎵)
Depression, therapy, and Stoicism.

Relationships are hard. It takes time to find good fits that can last the roughest storms. Regardless of how people feel about break-ups, they often have silver linings. We can decide whether it is going to destroy and debilitate us, or we can think about how we can grow from these experiences. On a personal note, I was deeply insecure, and social validation was my drug. My worth depended on the words coming from others. I took a defeatist attitude. It was not healthy, even for my best friends in whom I confided. This self-reflection made me realize the value of seeing a therapist to start healing.

Going to therapy made me aware of the fact that our behavior and reactions in the present are often linked to how we were raised and/or are due to a prior traumatic event. I will admit that societal and religious expectations played a role in why I felt I needed to “play my part” to be accepted. It was the constant fear of keeping up appearances for peers and family or the risk of being scrutinized by my community. Everyone aimed to impress each other: the focus was on who had the best house, car, attractive partner, well-behaved child, job, etc. The act of conforming was itself less harmful than the fear of being gossiped about or excluded from one's community.

My questions regarding the need for control lead me to Stoic philosophy. Stoicism taught me a few key points: 1) everyone is going to die someday (“*On the Shortness of Life*” by Seneca), 2) we can only control our actions, decisions, and judgments, not those of others (*The Enchiridion* by Epictetus), and 3) to thrive towards mastery of our mind and character (*Meditations* by Marcus Aurelius). My conclusion: if everyone dies eventually, why worry so much about the opinions of others? What is versus what isn't in my control? Am I too carried away by my emotions, and if so, what can I do to master them? How can I improve upon my character?

Summer's Duluth

(🎵)Notion – The Rare Occasions(🎵)
Finding love at the world's largest freshwater lake (by surface area).

Duluth was where my journey for emotional mastery began, and it was the perfect start. I spent most of my life on a tropical island, and the pseudo-ocean waters of Lake Superior felt familiar. It was my first adventure on my own, without friends or family or knowing anyone in the area. I arrived at Black Beach Park, and everyone was walking on the shore in coats and jackets. Can you guess what I did? I got into the cold, late-summer waters. People were intrigued by my mental exercise, to say the least. I viewed it as a challenge, to accept being uncomfortable. I was training myself, and when I was about to leave, two other guys arrived and were determined to show their Nordic heritage by swimming in the cold lake too. I did not miss an opportunity to show them what this Puerto Rican blood can tolerate.

From meeting Latinos on the Duluth ferry to sharing with the Hostel du Nord folks, walking the port, and finding local events and the Great Lakes Aquarium, being in Duluth taught me I can have fun on my own. One of the reasons I moved to the US was because I sought new experiences, new cities, and different climates. Looking back, I find it odd that

I thought I had to have people with me in order to justify going anywhere. Yes, going places with friends is awesome, but they are in the realm of what is not in our control. If you have the resources and the time, give yourself an adventure and see what happens. When you travel alone, you not only learn about nature, culture, places, and people, but you also learn more about yourself. I learned to love myself.

Autumn's Promise

(🎵)Sense – Last Dinosaurs(🎵)
Moving forward and the gift of the present.

“It is unfortunate. No, it's fortunate that this has happened, and I've remained unharmed by it — not shattered by the present or frightened of the future. It could have happened to anyone. But not everyone could have remained unharmed by it.” – Marcus Aurelius

Life is the best teacher. Though we endure heartaches and struggles, it is all part of the human experience. Forgiving ourselves, taking in feedback, and moving forward is the only way we can grow from our mistakes or perceived misfortunes. This is achieved by not giving up on ourselves, or the possibility of a better future. Eventually, we might even make peace with those we have had a falling out with. The more time we spend fixated on the past, the less we are able to appreciate the present. The Stoics think about death, not out of fear, but to remind themselves to appreciate what they have and how quickly it could all be taken away.

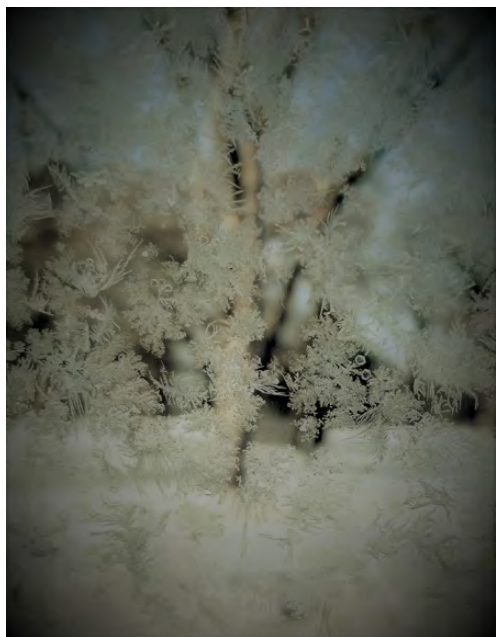
Autumn promises that the leaves that fall from our trees are only temporarily gone and will grow back when spring comes. I promise myself to do my best, to continue growing, to explore my mind through journaling, to read more, to acknowledge my lack of knowledge, to forgive, to love, to travel the world, and to live in the present moment, and most importantly, to move forward.

The End

(🎵)Apollo – Last Dinosaurs(🎵)

Ice Phage

BY ANJALI PANICKER



View the world through snow-tinted glasses

BY ANJALI PANICKER



Snow

BY ANANYA PAPPU



Keh Mukarni

BY ISRA ABDULWADOOD

Urdu Script:

رہے ہند ہو یہ بے گورہ ہند اب یں ہک نآ
رہے ہٹی ب تاس ہو یہ ب یں م نپ لے لیکا
یں ی ترزگ یں تار یں م چوس یک ی سا

ن ج اس ، ی خس لے آ
توم ، ی خس ان

Transliteration:

Aankhen bandh hoke bhi woh dikhe
Akelepan main bhi woh saat baithe
usi ki soch mein raatein guzarti hain

Aye sakhi saajan?
Na sakhi, mout.

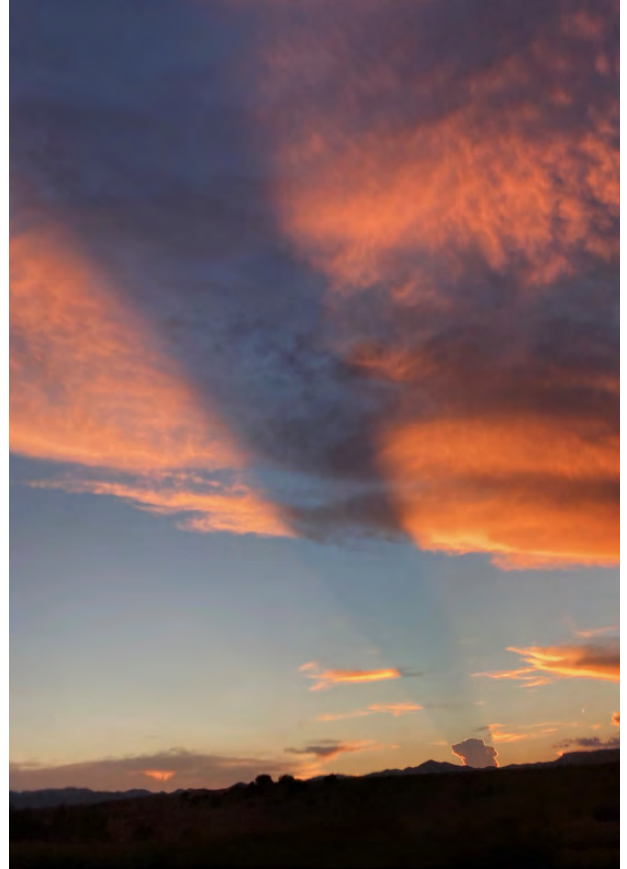
Translation:

Even with my eyes closed, I see him
Even when I'm alone, he sits with me
My nights pass thinking of him

Is it your lover, friend?
No dear, it is death.

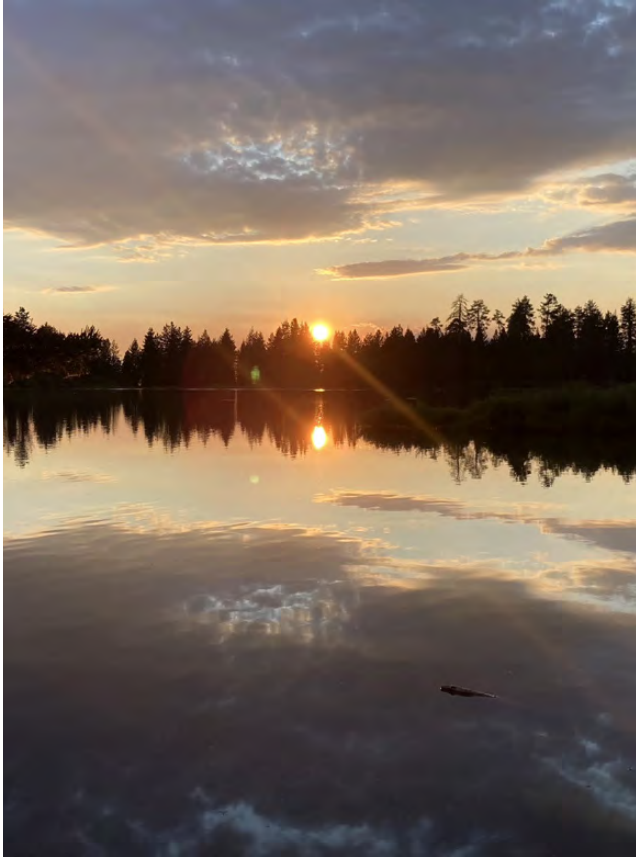
Nature's Spotlight

BY NING MCKENZIE



Riddled with Ripples

BY NING MCKENZIE



Trisomy Twenty-One: Haiku From Parallel Perspectives

BY MAIA YOUNG

Robbed of legacy
By praised genes now aneuploid:
“What’s lower than Down?”

Prayers preceded
Heaven-sent fissures and folds –
Up syndrome, indeed.

Curiosity

BY LAURA BUDVYTYTE



Spotted

BY LAURA BUDVYTYTE



Noise Complaint

BY SHERRY ZHOU

Obnoxious squawking
Assaulting tender ears
Edged with a metallic echo
Mocking that recurrent caw
Of the corvid megamurder

Warping high-pitched cries
Piercingly false, poor mimicry
Of the haunting, fierce song of birds of prey
Wrecked by being repeated, tied end to end,
With other miscellaneous mutated bird calls

Such ugly noise pollution
For half hours at a time
Three times a day
Subjecting all to torture
Disrupting the serene landscape
Of the downtown campus
Inciting sentiments of anger and hate
Instead of promoting peace and calm

There are other ways to deter
The downpours of droppings
Without spawning splitting headaches or
defiling bird calls or
shattering the tranquility—

Alas the waves of corvids only migrated
To other nearby areas
To continue their cacophonous, blanketing showers

I plead with you,
Please, please end the thrice-daily broadcast of the looped and warped bird calls.

Winter Rider

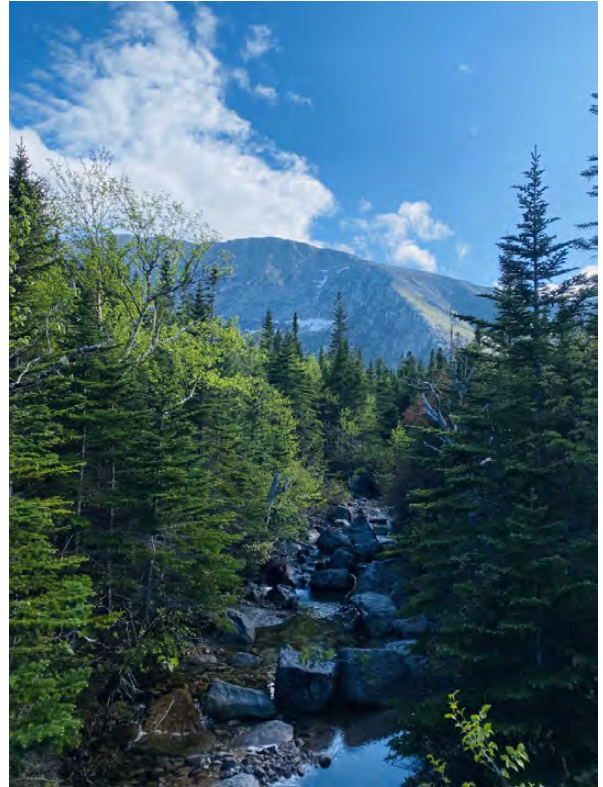
BY HANNAH HABERECHT

Linocut print on paper



Mount Katahdin

BY LAUREN JENNINGS



T(r)ucked Away in the Mountains

BY REWAN ABDELWAHAB



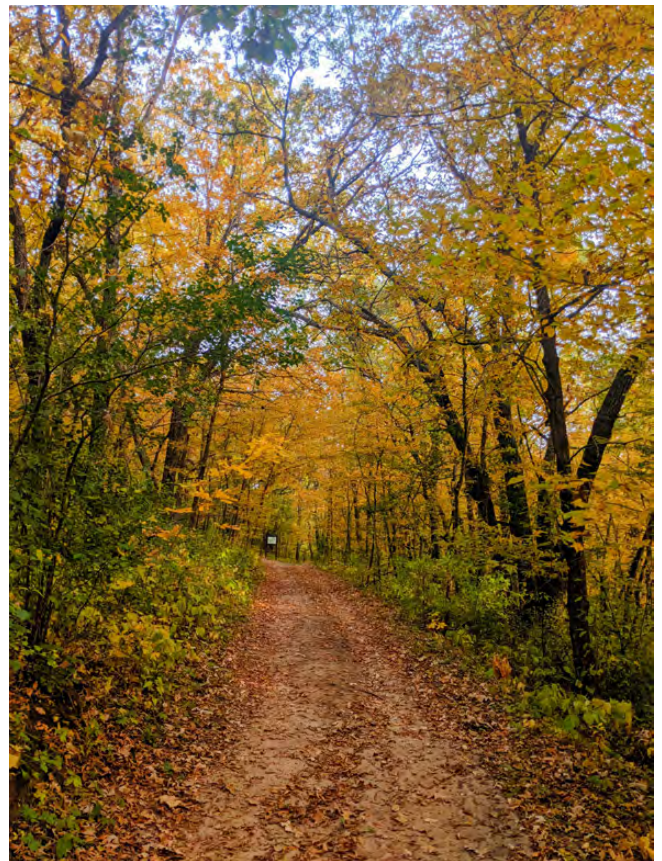
Beauty in the Ordinary

BY LAURA BUDVITYTE



Untitled

BY JENNIFER FEIGIN



Passion

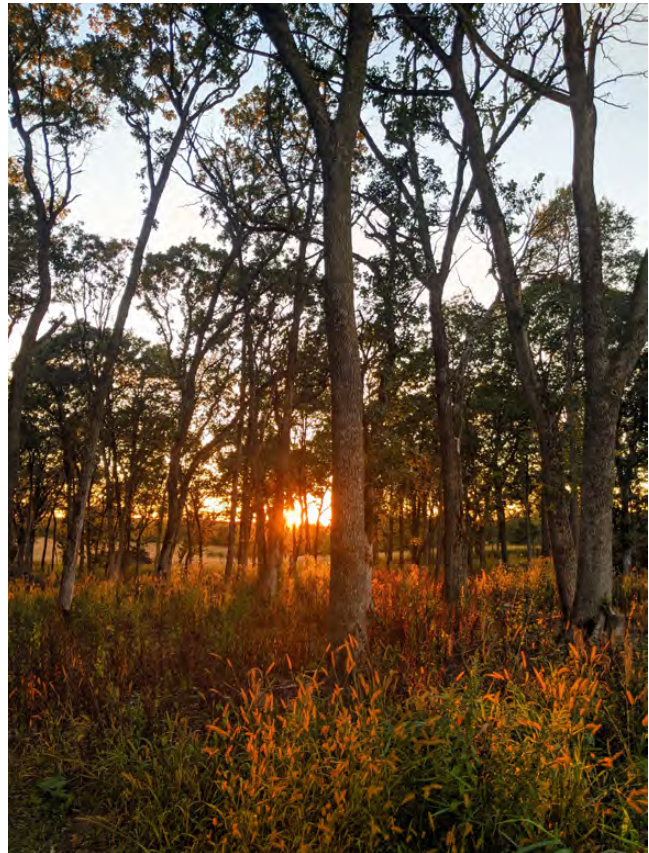
BY NEHA DEO

If my love was the fire that you needed,
Why did you let me burn?



Untitled

BY JENNIFER FEIGIN



Untitled

BY LEDA WANG



Delicate Views from Denmark

BY LAUREN BUDVITYTE



Pizza and Appendicitis

BY NATE GIPE

The hospital room was nice enough. It had a window overlooking an arboretum and a cemetery, through which the morning light streamed in. A nondescript painting of a sailboat hung over my bed, which was guarded by sentinel IV poles on either side. A recliner chair near the window was covered by a white hospital sheet, wrinkled from where my mom had slept on it the night before. She sat on the edge of it now, wondering whether I did or did not have appendicitis.

The nurse asked, "What's your favorite food?"

"Pizza," I replied without hesitation. "And if there was a pizza in front of you right now, would you eat it?"

"Yeah," I answered, again without hesitation.

"Then I don't think it's appendicitis," reasoned the nurse. "If you had appendicitis, you wouldn't want to eat anything because of the pain."

I thought maybe she underestimated how much I loved pizza. But still, I wasn't convinced I had appendicitis either. My belly pain was just another symptom in a strange parade of occurrences that had landed me in the hospital yesterday with a diagnosis of leukemia... and now maybe appendicitis.

Later that day, Dr. Gowens, my newly-assigned pediatric oncologist, came by to examine my abdomen. She pressed my belly all over, astutely watching my face to see if I grimaced at any point during the exam.

"Does this hurt?" she asked.

"A little," I responded.

"Hm." Dr. Gowens turned so she could address me and my mother at the same time. "Well, we haven't ruled out appendicitis. It normally causes more significant pain, but can present in lots of different ways." She turned to me again. "Do you have a favorite food?"

"Pizza, for sure."

"And could you eat pizza right now, if I gave you some?"

"Yeah, I think I could."

"Hm. Well, here's what I think. We'll need to clarify the diagnosis before we initiate chemo, so we'll order an abdominal ultrasound. They'll come by later today to take you to the ultrasound suite, and we'll get some imaging. If you have appendicitis, we'll pick up the swelling. Sound good?"

I nodded my head in affirmation.

Later that evening I arrived at the ultrasound suite, a darkened room that seemed warmer than the rest of the hospital. A man booted up the ultrasound machine and started pressing a probe over my lower abdomen. Grainy greyscale images pulsed on his screen, full of information to him but completely unintelligible to me.

"Do you see appendicitis?" asked my mother.

The ultrasound man smiled apologetically. "Sorry, I'm not allowed to interpret results for you. But I'll send this report to the doctors and you'll have answers soon."

The next morning, the rest of my family came to visit. I was so excited to see them, we didn't even talk about my cancer diagnosis. At some point, Dr. Gowens came in and I got to introduce everyone to her.

"Well, the ultrasound report came back, and it turns out you do have appendicitis." She outlined the plan: surgery would be scheduled to remove my swollen appendix, and chemo would begin as soon as I recovered from the operation.

Turns out, the nurses and doctors had underestimated just how much I loved pizza.

In the afternoon, a hospital transporter wheeled me down to pre-op. There I

met the surgeon who would be doing my appendectomy. He had the same name as me, Nathaniel. I took that as a good omen. "I've done thousands of appendectomies," he assured me with a smile. "You're in great hands."

As soon as one nurse finished explaining the procedure to me and getting my consent, another came in to explain the anesthesia. At some point, someone in the room gave me a shot of a drug they called Versed through my IV. On the way to the operating room, I felt the drug hit. Suddenly, I was numb and fuzzy and heavy and light at the same time.

* * *

Every Friday, for as long as I could remember, my family had followed this routine, to the point that it was basically a sacred ritual to me. Dad would pick up a movie from Family Video on his way home from work. Almost immediately after he'd come through the door, he'd start making pizza dough. I'd watch as he mixed the flour, water, and yeast, amazed at how everything came together. He'd then prep toppings, slicing up peppers, mushrooms, and olives with a mesmerizing deftness and scraping them into neat piles on the cutting board. After browning sausage and mixing the sauce, he'd retrieve the dough, which he had placed in a bowl under a wet towel. With a flourish, he'd whip off the towel, revealing that the dough had magically doubled in size! After separating the dough into two balls, he'd place one in the middle of each of our pizza pans, using the heel of his hand to spread the two dough balls into circles. *Bake the dough for 15 minutes at 425 degrees, brush the crust with butter, add sauce, pepperoni, sausage, and vegetable toppings on one pizza for the parents, but not on the second for the kids. Top with mozzarella, back in the oven for another 15. While the pizza cools, set the table and assemble condiments: red pepper flakes for Dad, ranch for Jackie, Maggie,*

THE TEMPEST

and Sam, parmesan for everyone. Pour beverages: water for Dad, Mom, Katie and Maggie, off-brand lemon-lime pop for everyone else. There was a process to everything. It was a perfectly timed, choreographed routine that culminated in a family of eight sitting around a large kitchen table, my siblings and I scarfing down pizza as quickly as possible so we could taste one more delicious bite before our stomachs told us we were already full.

During dinner, Mom would rap her knuckles against the table on at least two separate occasions to signal me to keep all four chair legs on the floor. Over the course of the meal, at least one of us, and often two, would spill our drinks as we stretched to grab for more pizza, more toppings, or a refill of pop. Dad would tell us what movie he had brought home, and I'd inevitably find something wrong with it— it wasn't animated, I'd never heard of it, it was too old. At the end of the meal (and to my mother's chagrin), we'd fold our paper plates in half, lift them to our mouths, and pour all the parmesan cheese that had fallen off our pizza slices down the hatch to top it all off.

Then, we'd quickly clear and wipe off the table, wash the pizza pans, and argue about who would have the onerous task of sweeping the floor. We'd run up the stairs, whip on our pajamas, grab our pillows and fleece blankets, and sprint back down the stairs to the family room to claim the best viewing spaces. There was never enough couch space for everyone, and at least one armchair was always reserved for Mom, so most of us ended up on the floor, nestled in our bundles of blankets. To keep us all well-supplied during the movie, Dad would make three large salad bowls worth of popcorn on the stovetop in the rotary popper, adding liberal butter and white cheddar seasoning. And then, curled up warm and cozy on the carpeted floor of the family room, we'd all watch the movie together. And despite my previous

protestations, I always enjoyed whatever movie Dad had brought home.

In middle school, it occurred to me to ask Dad to teach me how to make pizza, so that I could make it any time I wanted. He recited the recipe to me, and I wrote down every detail, no matter how seemingly insignificant or miniscule: pepperoni goes on *first*, cheese goes on *last*. Keep in the oven until you get just a few brown spots on the cheese. Slice into halves, then in quarters, then each quarter into thirds to get 12 pieces out of each pizza. After a few hit-and-miss attempts, I was able to reliably replicate Dad's pizza— although my family frequently complained I added too much oregano to the sauce. I have made the pizza every Friday night since then.

* * *

The next thing I remember was waking up in a hospital bed with a terrible burning feeling in my throat. I was having a hard time understanding where I was. My eyes couldn't seem to focus on anything solid in the room. Suddenly, I realized that in addition to whatever the heck was going on in my throat, I was horribly nauseous. Almost unbidden, my body leaned forward and promptly vomited. As I looked up, one of the shapes in the room resolved into Dad, who was handing me a red popsicle. It was just what I needed. The sweetness cleared the taste of bile from my mouth, and the coolness soothed my searing throat. After I finished it, I fell asleep again. I woke up in my hospital room, feeling much better, except for a terrible ache in my abdomen. Anytime I coughed, or sneezed, or laughed, the pain intensified to an almost unbearable level.

That night, my older sisters Jackie and Katie hung out with me while the rest of my family took my mom out to give her a break from hospital duty. We scanned through the catalog of hospital movies on my TV. I scrolled through and

quickly found *Mrs. Doubtfire*, which I recognized but had never seen.

"Oh my gosh, it's SO funny, you have to see it!" said Jackie. I sat in the middle of my hospital bed in a bundle of blankets, Jackie and Katie on either side, curled up like we used to on the floor of the family room. We started *Mrs. Doubtfire*. There was no popcorn to go with the movie, but that was alright. Every time Robin Williams did something funny, I would start to laugh, feel a terrible pain in my abdomen, and then make almost-silent wincing noises as I continued trying to laugh, unable to stop despite the pain. Jackie and Katie were concerned and asked if I wanted to watch something different.

"No," I said, breathless from pain, "This is great!"

And it was.

Untitled

BY JENNIFER FEIGIN



Hammocking in the Aspens

BY GORDON XIE

Digital artwork made with Procreate and Pixelmator



To fit in or stand out
is the question

BY ANJALI PANICKER



The City

BY SUNNY BOBORI

What is this place, a maze of redeeming grace?
Weaving streets, checkered alleyways,
Streaming cars, a buzzing craze
Glory and luster coming from a twinkling adjuster
Commanding traffic to rave or to halt
Beauty etched in light on every street corner
Look, "Food is ready," "Barbershop." Ah, a movie theater!
Turn around, down yonder is a man with no shelter
Begging bread, he pleads, "help the hungry!"
Across from him is a pool of standing water
Upon which a drainage pipe relieves its obtuse gutter
Standing there, I think, wow, what a fuss!
Such fervor and style mark a variegated tenor
But, let me stand awhile and bask in this splendor
I am happy, for I know that the city is for all of us

Orlando, FL – It's not a Waffle House, it's a Waffle Home

BY SCOTT ANDERSON



six impossible things before breakfast

BY LEDA WANG

(i) - *there's a potion that makes you shrink*

Even from early days of childhood
never have I known of this mine own life
how much of time passes in wakeful state
how much of it in but vivid dreaming.

But one thing there is that I remember—
preserved like a carefully pressed flower
from the garden of my young memory—
a small bedroom with peeling wallpaper,
with red bookshelves and a carpeted floor.

No clock therein marked the passage of time,
yet nonetheless could I tell all too well
by sudden chills and quivers down my spine,
by thunders and shudders of my pulses,
rat-tat tattoo of war drums in mine ears;

That prowling sneaking slithering approach:
dark unfurling, scent of sweet atropine
heralding the third hour past mid of night.
Then does a quiet coiling in embrace
overtake my hollowed bones.

In vast depths
sedates and sinks any last resistance;
in place calls out abyssal voice to me,
gauzy yet pond'rous, whisp'ring from the grave,
no sound save that it makes in mine own head:

*"Arise, lost little bird, come follow me;
away, and leave behind your coffin-cage
of mortal flesh and blood, sinew and bone.
Arise, for 'tis I who shall lead you home."*

So docile I rise, my soul unfettered
yet bound up anew, then not yet aware
of what I shall be when I am thus lost,
nor of how, having tilted back my head
to lap at nectar of false creation,
have I so shrunk, become so very small.

But in the now of present-past I float
like ghost through empty halls, forsook of form
though not of mind. Perhaps I always knew
how to fly, or rather to swim as does
a silv'ry darting fish through stagnant air.

On I drift 'til air to amber turneth,
entrapping me like a little stuck fly;
then down, down I fall, into gaping maw
entombed, still clawing in silent screaming.

(ii) - *and a cake that makes you grow*

When next mine eyes can see, I find myself
in a room of many doors, a whirlwind
of size and shape and colour; in number
ornate and plain the same innumerable.

Up, up they rise, layer upon layer—
craning tower, giant unto heaven—
the glowering peak lost to altitudes
of a cavernous echoing darkness,
far past where light can gleam on forlorn walls.

From where I rise as pawn on chessboard floor—
a composition of deathly cold stone—
rumbling, not heard by ear but felt by bone,
loudly growls and then louder bellows
roaring high'r the fire of dread within.

Birds flee before a tempest; so likewise
make I an attempt to flee. But as pawn
forward one square only can I move, then
rooted I become, as like was Daphne
turned to laurel by river's edge.

Before mine eyes, open wide the doors burst;
with booming crash of dark churning water
as it surges faster and faster still.
Panic arrives, a burning frostbite blade;
and with its wintry sister of despair,
strikes and lodges deep in mine empty bones.

Thrown about, pummelled black and blue I am
by rabid raging of sharp murd'rous waves;
then, hangs by spider silk before mine eyes
as if 'twas an off'ring to Tantalus,
an offal cake of blood and suffering,
sticky hot, still in the last throes of death.

*"Eat me," it whispers, shiv'ring in delight;
"choke on me," it throbs, in my silent mind;*

*"Allow me to crawl my way down your throat;
for the gift of a chance for you to grow
in return you shall offer me your heart
which I shall take to make hive and burrow."*

In blind hope I gag down its bitterness;
alas, a curse upon naïveté
as the larva of writhing wretchedness
tunnels its way into weeping heart-flesh
and consumes me as would a corpse so be
by bubbling masses of pallid grave-worms.

(iii) - *animals can talk*

And yet in peak of mourning, all sudden
do the seething salty waters recede;
drying away invisible, as would
tracks of old tears upon a child's face.

No longer am I trapped and rooted fast;
but neither do I float. In me there is
a weight which has me to barren earth bound.
Mayhaps it is the water in my lungs;
mayhaps it is the larva, now asleep
but growing ever larger all the same.

In a far-off corner of near darkness
swings open a door, wood old, plain, and worn;
a beguiling scent of ghostly lilies
and chorus of reedy lilting voices—
enticing tendrils coaxing forth my soul—

Cross the threshold, I enter a garden
where roses with faces like dolls so fair
turn to their neighbours to peer and murmur
and tinkling bluebells play a melody
spun dripping sugar sweet in mid-day sun.

At a tea party laid out beneath all
chatters away hatter, hare, and dormouse;
amidst them a flying whirl of china,
every set mismatched in form and lacquer.

With eyes of wild glee does hare spy me
and twirls me into a deeply plush chair;

*"Sit!" it cries, "and do have yourself some tea!
For many drear an aeon has it been
since in Underland your kind last was seen."*

So obliging, a sip of concoction
I take. Bitter-sharp its taste coats my tongue;
with it comes a dreadful urge for retching.
In politeness I swallow down bile,
but still oozes from me a poisoned sludge.

Now an eerie dark like that concoction
is vaulted sky and gleam in hatter's eye.
Voices now all in piercing sibilance—
a dissection, a peeling back of flesh—
quiet consensus of damning judgement.

Looming high over me, gazes profound,
as monoliths hatter, hare, and dormouse;
a cup on saucer like gavel strikes;
resonant in condemnation it rings,
summary dismissal, silent conveyed:
you are not who you are supposed to be.

(iv) - cats can disappear

"Wanderer adrift through barren wasteland"
a landscape picture would be so titled.
Thus am I adrift as a boat cut loose
wand'ring through foreign that seems familiar.

Once upon a time, or perhaps it was
in a distant future yet to occur,
this land brims full of the lushness of life,
gleams golden glorious in its beauty.
In present it is but a decayed thing
a twilight tableau of an anguished gloom.

Things hidden live by quiet chittering
in places unseen daily scuttering;
but upon my hand, then kissed to my cheek,
apparition places its phantom paw.
Eyes like emeralds, a crescent-moon grin—

Gentlest touch, gentlest I have ever felt
lures me forward as yellow flame does moth.
Voice like salted cream: low, smooth in mine ear—
"Pay them no mind," it croons, "for they are mad.
We are all mad here, even you and I."

Air to smoke, to a sublimed solid form—
feline in grace, silky iridescence—
about me twirls, being ever in motion.
"Cheshire," it beams and bows; "at your service."

"Cheshire," says I, "mighty pleased to meet you.
Won't you please tell me, my goodly kind sir,
if this land here is not where I belong
why can I not fly from realm so bizarre?"

"In minds you and I be one and the same,"
replies the cat whose name is Cheshire.
"I can hardly know more than you my dear;
but a guide am I, for your weary soul—
if 'tis wished I could show you where to go."

"Oh Cheshire," says I, "thank you ever so,
for long have I been a lost wanderer,
my heart weighed on me heavy and bitter;
alas, would that I could but find my way,
to become what I am supposed to be."

Cheshire smiles—enigmatic regard—
one eye like Castor, the other Pollux,
its grin a sextant, face an astrolabe.
With great aplomb guides me, the lone sailor—
a winged ship on silent night-dark waters.
A clearing reached, and Cheshire disappears;
into mine ear, as one last parting purr:
"Fear not my dear, for all paths lead to Rome."

(v) - there is a place called Wonderland

In the clearing, a great caterpillar
reclines on a pillowy red toadstool;
its face so young, yet old too and wizened,
body a dreamy blue, veiled in thick clouds—
heady incense of its own-self making.

"Hello," says I, voice but a hoarse whisper.
"Sir Cheshire it was who brought me hither
bid me seek your guidance, for you would know,
O, great Absolem, how to send me home."

A ring of smoke carries voice like a tomb,
"Foolish youngling, how could you still not know?
From this place, which you once called Wonderland,
there is no escape for you. How canst thou
flee as would a bird before a tempest
when the winds that rail are in thine own mind?"

Thought I before that I knew of despair
but then still had I looked for escaping.
Trapped in hellscape of mine own fashioning—
horrors foreign that seemed familiar;
or rather, familiar become foreign—
now at long, long last could I clearly see
with eyes stained no more by treach'rous roses;
'tween blood and bile I recognise it
and know ever after I always shall.

Believe I with the dry husk left of me
already in soul am I dead and gone;
only my bloody heart does not yet know,
for onward, incessantly, still it beats;
only my strangled lungs do not yet know,
gluttonous, they gulp and devour air.

Absolem coughs, echoing impatience,
"Foolish youngling, of what use is despair?
To what end is your insipid wailing?
Save us or doom us, decide it quickly.
Either slay the vicious devastation
which has burrowed into your heart; or else,
should you fail once more, stand back and let it
|devour us whole."

"But Absolem," cry I,
"how possibly can I do what you say?
Tear out mine own heart, impaled on a blade,
the murderess of mine own broken soul?"

To this great Absolem has his reply,
"'Tis not murder, but alchemy instead,
to purge the impurities from your soul.
Alike are you and I, one and the same;
almost who we were always meant to be."

(vi) - I can slay the Jabberwocky

Smoke in mine eyes, roaring waves in my blood.
In the courtyard of a crumbling castle
where above rages a storm, from my chest
breaches my firstborn, first breath a burble.
With its jaws that bite and its claws that catch,
ravenous monster, it ingurgitates
all within its reach.

At last it turns 'round
to stare me boldly, coldly in the eyes;
its eyes are mine, like in colour and shape,
lit by fire of pale magnesium,
a death sans mercy promised in their depths.

Once a larva it was, kept warm and safe;
dearly beloved and tenderly hated,
it was always both in every drawn breath.
Now grown large as a menacing mountain,
'tis a devil, baying hungry for pain;
still 'tis my child, mine own blood and bone;
familiar once, but foreign to me now.

Cold distant stars rule not our destinies;
nevertheless must I act by their light
in my journey of divine alchemy,
slice off vice of mortal flesh bit by bit
'til the soul that's left is lighter than air.

Six impossible things there are to count
before I may awake; the last I count
in breaths carefully metronome-measured:
"six, six, I can slay the Jabberwocky."

With nostrils flared that Jabberwocky scents
my dreadful, foolhardy, reckless resolve;
open wide gapes its sticky foul-smelt maw.
From desperation unto death I forge
bright-shining armour and a gleaming shield,
fortress to ward off the beast's deadly wrath.

Cracks of lightning, amongst abyssal dark;
inside my heart, within my soul a light;
behold—hope!—it is mine own Vorpall blade!
Sings the Vorpall blade as I draw it forth, a
cruel cry, cautery to pestilence,
blood price paid for decisive victory.

Screeches shrill and high the Jabberwocky
frantic, hissing in terrified fury;
it dives at me, its intent to devour.
But high leap I, Vorpall blade raised aloft—
snicker-snack it goes, 'cross its scaly neck—
falls on pale stone the Jabberwocky dead,
rolls 'cross the courtyard its spined severed head.

(vii) - & fin.

The pale light of morning, robed silver bright,
pours past slits in the blinds of my window.
As drowning man at last breaches surface,
so I gasp, open lips against my shroud
and breathe in scents of pine and West Lake mist.

At long last I wake from my deep slumber,
cracks of my soul fuse with the molten gold
of dawn's first blush, indigo and purple
to glowing red and brilliant orange,
painted by fairfolk brush through wispy clouds.

All mimsy now are the borogoves,
gyre and gimble they are in the wabe;
as the tender tendrils of new green life
lift up their fiddleheads toward the sky—
I know by my heart that they are just so
in my mind's Wonderland. Cross that land now
has the blood of the Jabberwocky spread;
and where that dark tar-like ichor drenches,
time it turns and loops; time it does renew.

As on my balcony I breathe and stand
flutters toward me a blue butterfly,
wings iridescent with cobalt rainbow.
"Hello Absolem," says I, smiling soft.
*"It looks like we did become exactly
who we were both always meant to be."*
Away drifts he, rising high on a draft
'til no longer he can be by eye seen.
But I know well now that by turn of night
I'll see him in Wonderland once again.

No longer am I afeared of that thing
which erst dwelt in hollows betwixt my ribs;
Charybdis it was, old legend reborn.
For its sake I once braved turbulent seas,
all for a glimpse at the eye of the storm;
a drowning sea-bird: battered and broken,
not meant to conquer such violent waters.

"Come at me now, Jabberwocky!" crow I,
vast mountains ahead echo through and through,
*"Come try me now, if even you still dare!
For I have slain you once, cut you in twain;
and I shall slay you again and again
ere you have hope of chance to vanquish me!"*

Sanguine in blood and hope I face the day,
though I know full well what the night shall bring.
But at last beneath me I hear a stir,
as house and home slowly rustle awake.
Away I turn, from miraculous sight;
for it is time at last for me to break my fast.

Blue Bantam

BY HANNAH HABERECHT

Gouache on paper



Mayo Pride

BY NING MCKENZIE

Acrylic on canvas



For the Birds

BY NATHAN CHOW

The day drags
My head down to those tomes.
Strands of hair bartered for grey knowledge,
Medical secrets for the low, low price of youth.

Beyond the window I watch ruby-chested Life fly,
He stops at some flowers, sips sweet nectar,
Sings simple songs born of nothing more to do
Simply nothing beyond the nearby sky to aspire.

I bend to my book—when again I look,
he's gone.

spelling bee

BY EILENE YANG

sometimes in medical school
i question if i can read

ceftizoxime, cefuroxime, cefotaxime
do those look like different words to you

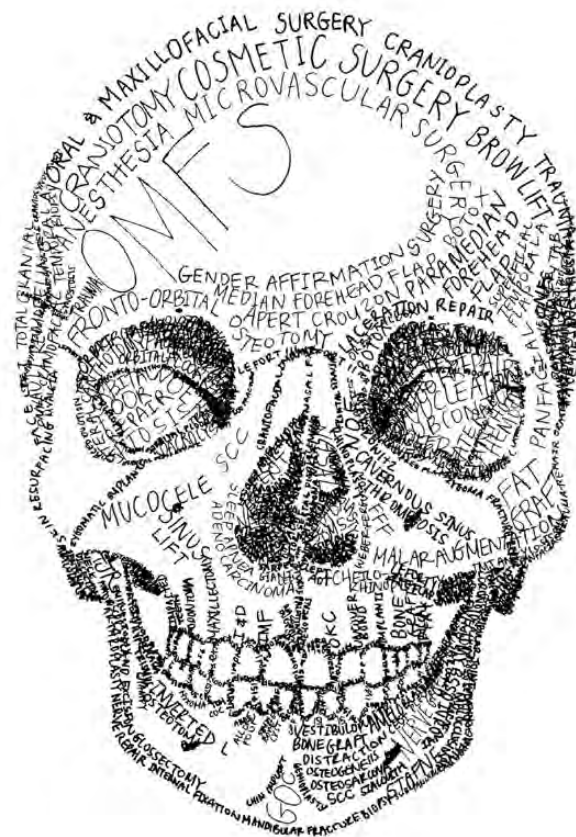
ecthyma, erythema, emphysema, empyema
could you please use those in a sentence

a syllable replaced or a life erased
spelling is now such high stakes

Spelling Bee

BY YULIYA PETUKHOVA

Pen on paper



Moon Light

BY REWAN ABDELWAHAB



After the Storm

BY NEIL SINHA



2023 Editorial Team



Sherry Zhou is a third-year M.D.-Ph.D. student and first year BMB Ph.D. student on the Rochester campus. Her professional interests lie in medical oncology of endocrine neoplasia and use of biochemistry and chemical biology to investigate tumorigenesis. She grew up in Vancouver, Canada, and has lived in the Bay Area of California and in Cambridge, MA. She is passionate about sustainability, teaching and mentorship, and working with underprivileged and underserved communities. She enjoys all things philosophical, sportsy, tinkerable, outdoorsy, and creative.



Patrick Brennan is a fourth-year medical student at Mayo Clinic in Rochester, MN pursuing a career in internal medicine. Originally from Columbus, OH, he previously studied oil, acrylic, and digital painting prior to medical school. In his spare time he enjoys grilling, gaming, skiing, hiking, movies with friends, chicken wings, and putting hot sauce on everything.



Diana Hla is a third-year medical student at the Jacksonville campus interested in surgery and critical care. She is additionally curious about health policy, disparities, and AI applications to health. Creative writing and journalism have always been a passion of hers—both writing and editing. Born and raised in Washington, DC, she also has spent time in Baltimore, MD and did the first two years of medical school at the Rochester campus. Her free time is spent irritating her little brother and on her hobbies: singing, martial arts, trapeze, and figure skating.



Yeonsoo Sara Lee is a third-year medical student coming to you from the sunny, sunny destination location of Mayo Clinic Jacksonville (the objective best campus). She has been a little nomadic in her lifetime, but tells people she is from North Carolina (high school was a formative time). She was a fieldwork ecologist in a former life before medical school, and adores being outdoors, including hiking, climbing, camping, and lazing on a beach. She also adores art (drawing, painting watercolors and acrylics, medical illustration) and is self-taught. She recently wrote, illustrated, and published a children's book called *The ABCs of Anatomy*. If you would like to examine her digital presence, she has an Instagram you can follow (if you feel so inclined) @ysaralee_art.



Emily Stickney is a third-year medical student at the Rochester campus. She plans to pursue a residency in Internal Medicine and potentially subspecialize down the line. In her free time, she enjoys hiking, drawing, painting, and playing soccer. If you want to see more of her work, you can follow along on her art Instagram (@emilystickneyart).



Guozhen (Gordon) Xie is a second-year medical student at Mayo Florida. He was born in China and grew up in Ohio, where he went on to attend college at Ohio State. Gordon is interested in cardiology and oncology and especially enjoys learning inpatient medicine. In his free time he enjoys running, painting, and playing violin. His artistic endeavors began in elementary school, when his botched attempts at drawing pokemon eventually convinced him to let his dad give him art lessons.

2023 Contributors



Rewan Abdelwahab is a third-year medical student interested in health disparities and oncology. In her free time, she loves to spend outside outdoors, play tennis, ride her electric scooter, and read. She enjoys learning and exploring a variety of artistic crafts including cross-stitching, calligraphy, singing, photography, and poetry among others. She is honored to be featured alongside so many talented artists.



Sunday (Sunny) Bobori is a first-year Post-Baccalaureate Research Education Program (PREP) scholar at Mayo Clinic, Scottsdale, Arizona. Born and raised in Nigeria, Sunny came to the US for his undergraduate studies. Sunny is currently a member of Dr. Clifford Folmes' Stem Cell and Regenerative Metabolism lab. He enjoys watching movies, reading classic novels, listening to music, and playing soccer in his free time.



Isra Abdulwadood is a first-generation, second-year medical student at Mayo Arizona. She grew up in Dallas, TX where she also went to school and graduated with a B.S. in Neuroscience and minors in Art History and Political Science in 2021. As one can tell from her degree choices, she loves indulging her niche interests and is interested in the intersection of plastic and reconstructive surgery and palliative care. In her spare time, she enjoys hiking, baking bread, collecting postcards, and café hopping.



Lauren Breslin is a fourth-year medical student at the Rochester campus. She is pursuing residency training in internal medicine and is interested in bioethics and medical education. She is originally from Colorado and attended UNC Chapel Hill for undergrad. She enjoys weightlifting, golf, skiing, baking and spoiling her two Yorkies, Rowdy and Mowgli. Her favorite flapdoodles ice cream flavor is Dark and Twisted.



Scott Anderson is a member of the Class of 2024. Raised in Georgia but born in Utah, whether he is as redneck as he claims is a subject of debate among few. Besides earning an economics degree at BYU, he tried stand-up comedy there one time. He plans to pursue a career in surgery and health care administration. He is a huge fan of Waffle House, or at least he was at the time of publication.



Laura Budvytyte is a first-year medical student at Mayo Clinic Arizona. She immigrated from Lithuania to the San Francisco Bay Area in California. Her interests are underserved medicine and all things infectious including pathology, infectious diseases, and a good laugh. She took a brief hiatus from medicine to “work” in a brewery and in rehabilitating seals and sea lions. Her passions include environmental sustainability, traveling, hiking, finding good coffee, and hearing new ways to mispronounce her last name.



Mazeed Aro-Lambo is an MD/MS student at Mayo Rochester. Born and raised in Brooklyn, NY to Nigerian parents, Mazeed developed an interest in writing during his middle school years. Though he first started writing poetry to impress girls, he has since returned to the craft with a new purpose—to explore and understand the world around him.



Nathan Chow is a 4th year medical student who is starting to appreciate the saying “life’s a highway”. His hobbies include gardening, cooking, and judging people based on the quality of their cookware, and he is excited to be starting his internal medicine residency in July.



Nate Gipe is a third year medical student at Mayo Rochester planning on applying to family medicine residency back in his home state of Michigan. Outside of medicine, he enjoys bird watching, jigsaw puzzles, hiking around Rochester’s many parks, and hosting movie nights with homemade popcorn.



Neha Deo is a fourth medical student at Mayo Rochester, originally from Vancouver (Canada) but was born in Fiji. In her spare time, she enjoys working out and eating tacos from Francis Tacos. She will be applying for dermatology residency this year. She hopes to build a clinic and alleviate poverty in her motherland. She is also a hypebeast and her favourite brand is Supreme.



Hannah Haberecht is a second year medical student on the Rochester campus, she has no idea what medical specialty she is interested in. In her free time she loves to go on bike-packing adventures, refurbish old furniture, and experiment with different art mediums.



Elizabeth Farkouh is a second-year medical student at Mayo Clinic Rochester. After spending her childhood in New York City and Toronto, she went on to receive her Bachelor of Science in Human Development from Cornell University. Outside of school, she enjoys acting in film and local theater, singing, and photography. She is passionate about medical humanities and addressing social and behavioral determinants of health.



Lauren Jennings is a third-year Ph.D. candidate in Biomedical Engineering and Physiology. She is interested in the field of regenerative medicine and researches cell therapy for Type 1 diabetes. She would not have made it this far in graduate school without the support of her friends and family, Spotify, and TikTok. When not in the lab, she enjoys baking, learning about plants, live music, playing soccer, and hiking.



Jenn Feigin is a first year PhD student at Mayo. She is interested in bioengineering, immunology, and computational biology research. Professionally, she hopes to apply her scientific knowledge to further the development of novel immunotherapies and drug delivery platforms that improve disease outcomes. In her spare time, Jenn enjoys running, skiing (cross-country and downhill), reading fiction and non-fiction, baking bread, traveling, listening to classical music, and thinking up captions for the weekly New Yorker caption contest.



Yong-hun Kim is a third-year medical student at Mayo Rochester. Born in South Korea, he grew up in different states on the east coast and lived in the Bay Area, CA studying computer science at Stanford before moving to Minnesota. As a reformed programmer turned medical student, he is passionate about digital health innovation and health equity. In his free time, he enjoys playing the violin, cooking, and rock climbing.



Derrick Lewis comes from a military family and spent much of his childhood in Italy and Germany before moving to Boston for undergraduate education. Shortly after college, he worked as a paramedic in the greater Boston area for 5 years, then continued his education at the Mayo Clinic Alix School of Medicine. He enjoys travel, weightlifting, and binge-watching Netflix. This summer, he will start neurosurgery residency.



Dileep Monie is a seventh year MD-PhD student at Mayo Clinic in Rochester hailing from Edina, Minnesota. He completed his PhD in Immunology with a concentration in Regenerative Sciences and plans to pursue neurosurgery. Outside of school, he enjoys urban freeriding, brewing beer, designing things, making things, breaking things, and sometimes fixing things.



Jean Marrero-Polanco is a second year PhD student in the Molecular Pharmacology and Experimental Therapeutics track. Born and raised in Puerto Rico, he now enjoys exploring the winter wonderlands of the Midwest. His research focuses on using artificial intelligence to find biological and clinical insights from a wide range of datasets, mostly from Psychiatry. He is a psychology and philosophy enthusiast with a passion for understanding human nature. If you ever find him with his headphones on, he is probably listening to an audiobook to keep up with his Goodreads yearly goal. He also journals, like, a lot.



Anjali Panicker is a Ph.D. candidate who thinks she'll never run out of opportunities due to the ubiquity of immunology. She has studied Treg cells in autoimmunity and is currently researching antibodies in transplantation. Next, she might investigate eosinophils in allergy, or perhaps NK cells in maternal-fetal immunity. If you see an Indian girl wearing a nerdy t-shirt, biking around downtown Rochester, whistling, and calling out to tiny birds around dusk or dawn, odds are it might be her.



Ning McKenzie is a third-year medical student at Mayo Arizona from Berkeley, California. Her dream is to become a pediatric-trained dermatologist who cares for families through all stages of life. Although she is inexplicably fascinated by gross skin conditions, she spends most of her time enjoying beautiful things like Arizona sunsets, cat paws, cardamom spice, waking up in the outdoors, and organizing random class outings in the name of wellness.



Ananya Pappu is a first-year medical student at the Arizona campus. Although she has spent her more recent years in San Francisco and now Scottsdale, she is an east-coaster at heart, having grown up in New Jersey and attended college in Baltimore. Her artistic interests include nature photography, scrapbooking, and dancing the Indian classical style of bharathanatyam. In school, she continues to explore her interest in internal medicine and hopes to be able to serve minority communities in her future career.



Yuliya Petukhova is a third-year medical student at Mayo Rochester and resident in oral & maxillofacial surgery. She was born in Siberia, but grew up in Salt Lake City, Utah. In her free time, she enjoys gardening, skiing, drawing, painting and spending time with her two cats. Art interests include portraiture and all things dentistry and medicine! Follow her art creations on Instagram @artsy_surgeon.



Neil Sinha is a pleasant 20-something year old male with no significant past medical history who presents as a third year medical student at Mayo Clinic Arizona. He grew up in the Bay Area, California and enjoys being outdoors, reclaiming his past guitar skills, and pondering demographic changes in the world. He has recently begun reconsidering his specialty of interest and will perhaps give an update in the next issue of The Tempest.



Vyanka Redenbaugh is a master's student and research fellow at Mayo Rochester. She went to medical school in Ireland. She is passionate about immunology, medical education, swimming, and reading. She is grateful for all the wonderful people she has met in Rochester.



Taylor Viggiano is a fourth-year medical student on the Arizona campus and an Arizona native. She studied nutrition and biology as an undergraduate at Brown University and worked in the innovation space for several years before medical school. She is passionate about the use of preventive and integrative medicine in care. In her free time, she enjoys spinning, listening to music, attending stand-up shows and spending time with her family and friends.



Santiago Restrepo Castillo is a Ph.D. candidate in Virology and Gene Therapy working on mitochondrial genome engineering. He was born and raised in Medellín, Colombia, where he learned to play the piano. Growing up in a world devoid of gay role models, Santiago is devoted to becoming a man his younger self can look up to.



Leda Wang is a first-year medical student on the MCASOM Rochester campus. She is very probably the most pedestrian variant of human to ever exist, but in a sleep-deprived state she will occasionally present with a symptomatology of eccentricity and an actual personality, interspersed with regularly scheduled existential crises (when her piece of writing published here occurred). If she ever has enough time with which to cultivate her character as to become both less banal and of decent use—or at minimum a proper ornament—to society, she would enjoy listening to and playing classical music, reading literature, acquiring more semi- or sub-amateur skills, and planning how to “not perish alone as a total failure” become a modern Renaissance woman.



Marisa [Mah-DEE-sah] Salazar is a “fourth/sixth”-year medical student who started in the inaugural MCASOM AZ cohort 6 years ago. After some twists and turns involving family and parasite research, Marisa is applying to Med-Peds. In addition to her passion for health equity and working with patients who speak primary languages other than English, Marisa loves baking, spending time with family, watching international TV series, and writing poems when the inspiration strikes.



Dilina Weerapperuma is a third-year student in the Mayo Clinic School of Health Sciences DPT program and will graduate in May 2023. After graduation, he hopes to work with athletes in both pediatric and professional settings. Outside of school, Dilina loves to play soccer, play flute, and work out in the gym.



Eilene Yang is a first-year medical student with an interest in dermatology and health systems sciences. She grew up in Durham, NC before moving to Philadelphia, then NYC, then San Francisco and eventually landing in Rochester, MN. In her free time, she enjoys experimenting with new recipes and ingredients, taking care of her cats and chickens, and learning to ice skate.



Jessica Weng is a third-year M.D.-Ph.D. student on the Rochester campus with an interest in women's health and tumor immunology. She grew up in Minneapolis, MN and went to college in Houston, TX before coming to Rochester, MN. She is passionate about health equity and humanities in medicine. She enjoys trying new recipes, working out with friends, and exploring the city one restaurant at a time in her free time.



Maia Young is a rising fourth-year medical student who enjoys writing, singing, dog-walking, and people-watching. She taught herself to weave tapestries after a ministry trip to Israel in 2019 and ran her first half marathon with (regrettably) minimal training halfway through her third year of medical school.



Taylor Witter is a research technologist in the Department of Biochemistry and Molecular Biology on the Rochester Campus. She was born and raised in Honolulu, HI and grew up loving the outdoors, reading, and writing. She will be matriculating into an M.D. Ph.D. program this upcoming summer and is interested in women's health, medical oncology, and the medical humanities. Her favorite pass times are longboard surfing, reading fiction and poetry, writing, traveling, long distance running and yoga.

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